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CENTERPIECE

Keeping it clean: Counties look to combat litter with enforcement, education

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1 of 7



TJ Rollins, supervisor for Charles County litter control, right, gets ready to place signs to alert drivers of litter pic on Nov. 20.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

It's Thanksgiving and the dump is closed. However, don't look for a 15-foot cliff to dispose of your garbage.

But if littering or illegal dumping is occurring, there are proper channels to complain about it, either with county environmental services or local sheriff's office.

While Southern Maryland experiences littering and illegal dumping, each county monitors and handles the calls and complaints differently.

Littering is typically considered throwing small items along roadways or in parking lots, Frances Sherman, chief of Environmental Resources for Charles County, said. It includes accidental items that might blow out of trash cans or intentional littering like bottles and take out food waste chucked from vehicles.

Illegal dumping is more significant, she said. It's intentional and includes larger items like a mattress, couch or bathtub not properly disposed.

"Litter happens because of the intentional meaning where someone does not know the impact or does not care about the impact," Sherman said.

Charles sheriff's office issued six littering citations for littering or illegal dumping from Aug. 1, 2024 through Aug. 31, 2025. Two of those arrests were for dumping over 100 pounds. They issued one traffic citation for littering.

St. Mary's sheriff's office issued nine traffic citations and seven warnings. The St. Mary's County Sheriff's Office made five criminal arrests for illegal dumping, including a warrant for a 2023 case.

In Calvert County there were 162 calls for service, 56 case reports and 15 arrests for illegal dumping over the last year. The county also received 13 calls for service, seven case reports and no arrests for littering.

Time to cleanThe Alice Ferguson Foundation hosts the annual Potomac River Watershed Cleanup at Pascataway Park along the Potomac River, Michelle Hickerson, programs director at the foundation, said. At their last clean up in April, over 200 volunteers collected more than 2,000 pounds of trash.

“We remove everything that we can find,” Hickerson said.

But plastic, specifically plastic bottles, is the biggest item that gets picked up and can take “thousands of years to break down,” she said.

Litter crews with Charles County clean county roads every week, she said. The county government also hired contract crews to clean roads weekly as well. These roads do not include Route 301, Route 6 or other numbered state roadways, which are periodically cleaned by the State Highway Administration.

“As a nation as a whole, we produce more waste,” Sherman said. “We have a lot more packaging and we eat out a lot more.”

Littering is a problem in concentrated areas, Emma Green Ewing, executive director of the St. Mary’s River Watershed Association, said. When a person litters in an area, someone else is more likely to litter in that same area as trash becomes commonplace along roadways.

“We can clean up those areas. It can help stop the problem,” Green Ewing said. “If it already looks clean, you’re less likely to dump something out your window.”

Littering can clog storm drains, which can lead to localized flooding, she said. Plastic bags in the water can look like jellyfish then turtles and other animals sometimes eat them.

“It’s so hard to catch people” littering, Green Ewing said. “Even when you see somebody throw something out the window, there’s not much that you can do.”

Enforcement matters Typically complaints are called to the sheriff's office, Lt. Col. Dave Payne with the Calvert sheriff's office said. Every call is assigned to a deputy.

"Just seeing litter does not mean a crime has been committed," Payne said. "All of the factors surrounding it have to be looked at."

If someone wants to make a complaint about littering or illegal dumping, they should reach out to county government then the county will reach out to the sheriff's office, Payne said. If littering occurred on the highway, it would be a traffic citation.

If someone throws trash out of a moving vehicle, they can receive points on their driver's license, according to the traffic provision in the Maryland code. If there are multiple people in the car and it can't be determine who littered, the owner is responsible if in the vehicle. If the owner is not in the car, whoever is driving is responsible for the violation.

"We don't get a lot of them," Payne said of littering complaints. "We investigate them as best we can."

Complaints are addressed within 24 to 48 hours, Margaret Romero, assistant chief of Environmental Services for Charles County, said. When complaints are filed under illegal dumping, a crew will look for something that is an identifier, like a name or address, and report it to the Charles sheriff's office.

"Cleaning and removing the litter is an essential part, but we can't just clean roads," Sherman said. "If we just clean roads and we did not partner with the sheriff's office ... then we're just going to be spending a lot of money on picking up trash."

In Charles County, the court can order someone to clean up the trash or pay a fine, according to the county code. It starts with a \$235 penalty and an enforcement fee of \$650. Both would be a misdemeanor. A repeat violation within 12 months is \$500.

A violator can choose to pay the fine or ask for a court date, St. Mary's sheriff's office said. If the violator has a hearing in district court, the disposition of the case is up to the sitting judge.

A person who disposes of litter in violation of Maryland state law in an amount not exceeding 100 pounds, and not for commercial gain, is guilty of a misdemeanor and on conviction is subject to imprisonment not exceeding 30 days, a fine not exceeding \$1,500 or both.

A person who disposes of litter in an amount between 100 and 500 pounds is potentially subject to imprisonment for at least one year or a fine not exceeding \$12,500, or both, Maryland state law said.

"It's not something that is really common to happen where we actually see it," Capt. Ashley Burroughs with the Charles sheriff's office said. "There's so many different layers and levels to this."

The sheriff's office could receive a call for a couch on the side of the road and by the time someone gets there, the person who left the couch went back to retrieve it because it accidentally fell off a truck, Burroughs said.

"It's still in the system as illegal trash dumping, but in reality something fell off the truck and somebody picked it up," he said. "There was no intent to do anything wrong."

People can call the Charles sheriff's office on its nonemergency line or the environmental resources will reach out to the sheriff's office, Burroughs said. The sheriff's office goes through each call for littering and illegal dumping.

"Without enforcement, we really can't capture that audience that just don't care," Sherman said. "It's the education of trying to have them understand what the consequence of their litter is. It does have an impact on the community and the

living environment for everyone.

Next steps Having events, like hazardous waste disposal days, are helpful to educate people on how to keep an area clean, Green Ewing said.

The environmental resources department in Charles County visits schools to talk about recycling and the importance of litter prevention, Sherman said. They have increased their digital and social media presence and introduced Litterbug, the department's mascot.

"We talk about what is accepted in our recycling program, specifically at the curb ... because that's what kids know," Romero said. "How they properly dispose of it at home means that it's not going to end up as litter."

Cody Hance, environmental education and community programs coordinator at the Alice Ferguson Foundation, hopes to use his role to address waste in Southern Maryland.

The foundation works with the Nanjemoy Environmental Education Center in Charles County to update its ninth grade earth science curriculum, updated the "Talking Trash" curriculum and incorporated work from the Chesapeake Biological Laboratory in Calvert County, he said.

"If the community has not been educated about the importance of properly disposing of their waste, they are not going to know the impact that it has," Hickerson said.

Bottom line is, like an old wise owl once said, "Give a hoot, don't pollute."

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Disposing trash properly

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